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RAGHAVA GOWDA, Farmer-teacher

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invention—an elaborate milking machine that can milk cows and buffaloes using a set of reciprocating vacuum pumps with a gauge, a suction assembly unit and a bubble-free gasketed milk canister to collect the milk in—was hailed by scientists. He was also awarded the President's medal in 2002 for the manual milking machine he created.

The suction assembly has two sub-assemblies with a set of nipples and a stainless

steel plate on one side and transparent conduit pipes and a regulator valve on the other. The procedure is simple and can work with a hand pump or foot pedal, as well as with an AC and DC battery, in which case, no human intervention is required. As the machine creates the effect of a calf suckling the udders, it is not only painless but also soothing for the cows. It can milch about 15 litres of milk in three minutes flat.

After testing the machine for several months, Gowda introduced it in the market and sold it at Rs 6,000, more than one-fifth of the market value of existing devices. “We wanted it to be affordable to farmers,” says Gowda. “There were months when I slept only at 4 a.m., and the worst sufferer was my wife, Leelavati, as I would insist that she sit through the tests everyday, even though she had to go to school in the morning. She supported my endeavour both morally and monetarily as we spent more than Rs 2 lakh during this time. Thankfully my relatives supported me. My brother gave me Rs 50,000 and my son-in-law Kusumdhara not only backed me financially but also helped me put the product out in the market.”

The Milk Master has made inroads in the Indian dairy farming community, selling over 2,000 machines at Rs 9,000 today, in Gujarat, Uttar Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu and even Jammu and Kashmir. Gowda has a registered patent for his innovation, the right of which was sought for over Rs 1 crore recently by a company that wanted to market it commercially. “Yes, it was a lot of money, but we were never in it for the profit. I created it because I needed it, and now my effort is to see that small farmers benefit from it. I do not want to sell the patent to benefit some commercial establishment,” Gowda says that cows and buffaloes are an important part of every farmer's life and that is what makes his innovation valuable.

His greatest sorrow is that the Government has not created any subsidy to enable the small farmer to buy the milking machine. “Cows give us manure for our land and I have never purchased chemical fertilisers. They also eat all the waste that comes out of the farm and give us milk. This is all part of a farmer's life,” Gowda continues to get calls from across the country from small, nameless farmers who want to buy his product. As he answers these calls, he also improves their lives.